

Chapter 1

Worry and Generalized Anxiety

This synthetic chapter was written for the ANGEL-UserSim repository. It is not taken from any published manual.

Treatment

Begin each session by setting a short agenda with the client. Ask which worry has been most present this week, and agree on one topic to work on. If the client arrives in acute distress, postpone the agenda and first help them slow their breathing.

Teach the client to notice worry as a chain of thoughts rather than a fact about the future. Ask them to write down the worry, the evidence for it, and the evidence against it. When the client cannot find any counter-evidence, ask how a trusted friend would see the same situation.

Case Illustration

Sam, a 34-year-old nurse, worried every evening that she had made a mistake at work. She checked her phone repeatedly for messages from her manager and slept poorly. Over six sessions she learned to postpone worry to a fixed 20-minute period and to test her predictions. By the end of treatment her evening checking had dropped from about twenty times to twice.

Discussion

Worry postponement is not appropriate for every client. For clients whose worry concerns a real and current danger, such as an unsafe home, the therapist should address safety first and adapt the plan.